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PACE BET

BUILT THE TECHNOLOGY. NOW THEY MUST FIND CUSTOMERS, MARKET DOMINATED BY SPACEX • BY **PRADIP K. SAHA**

The ambition is clear, but scale poses a difficult question: who will buy what India's space companies are building, and at what price?

The customer base is thin—India's space industry remains heavily dependent on government demand, with Isro still the primary local anchor—leaving most of the country's $8.4-billion space industry dependent on overseas orders. Skyroot, for instance, expects two-thirds of its demand to come from overseas.

However, the export pitch is not so straightforward. Among major spacefaring nations, India's average launch cost per kg is the highest, because Indian rockets are expendable and fly only a handful of times a year.

A recent study by economists Alessio Terzi of the University of Cambridge and Francesco Nicoli of Politecnico di Torino estimated India's 2025 cost of delivering a kg of payload capacity to low-Earth orbit at $13,302—the highest among the six spacefaring regions it studied. The estimate is modelled from public cost data (government reports, academic papers, public documentation)